

Directory

Charles Gounod

1818–1893, FRENCH

Known primarily as the composer of the opera *Faust*, Gounod was born in Paris, his father a painter, his mother a piano teacher. After training at the Paris Conservatoire he spent three years in Rome, where he studied Palestrina and other composers of church music. Returning to Paris, he contemplated taking religious orders, but instead turned to writing opera, producing *Sapho* in 1851. The following year he married pianist Anna Zimmerman. The success of *Faust*, first staged in 1859, made him the most famous composer in France. He created 12 operas in total, but no other achieved comparable success. In the early 1870s, Gounod lived in England, founding the amateur choir that later became the Royal Choral Society. In his later years he primarily wrote religious oratorios, including *La Rédemption* (1882) and *Mors et Vita* (1885). His setting of *Ave Maria* (1859), based on a Bach prelude, has proved